



Cavendish Cards

FACILITATOR SHEET

A deck for naming sensory and niche-construction needs. Point at a card, or lay a few. No reading needed to play.

Two rules hold the whole thing up.

- **No scoring.** No points, no matching, no right answer, no winning. There is no wrong card and no wrong hand.
- **The child controls sharing.** Turning a card up is the child sharing it; the turn is the consent. You don't turn their cards over for them.

Five ways to play

Show me — *early years, anyone*

Pick the one card that's you right now. That's the whole game. Say back what you see: "Buzzy today. Okay." Under a minute.

Build my day — *a child and a support worker*

Lay a place, a weather, and a couple of what-helps cards. A sentence in pictures — *cave, buzzy, headphones*. You've been handed a design brief. Build the conditions. Two to five minutes.

Class weather — *a whole group*

Everyone lays a weather card face-up. The room's weather becomes visible. No one is named. Nothing is scored. Two minutes, and the group has a shared word for the day.

Map the edges — *older kids*

Walk the lily-pad cards across a timetable. Find where the hard transitions actually are — between focus and talking, rest and joining in. Self-advocacy, in their hands. Ten minutes.

Play as the environment — *staff training*

Deal a table of what-helps cards with needs that conflict — room to move against less talking, just one person against a full group. Build one habitat that holds them all. You'll feel neurological pluralism instead of hearing about it. Twenty minutes.

Sharing is the child's

The turn of a card is the consent. It plays out three ways:

- **Kept** — the spread stays face-down. Nothing is read until the child turns something up.
- **Shown by invitation** — the child hands the spread to one person they pick. A deliberate act, not standing permission.
- **Ambient only** — in group play, only the room's weather shows. No individual's cards, ever.

Interaction cards are the exception — they're made to be shown.

When a child lays "stuck"

Stuck is a lily pad. It's a place to land, not a failure. Read it as information: something in the environment isn't fitting yet. Don't push the child across. Ask what would help them land — or offer a what-helps card and let them choose.

How to respond, in three moves

- 1 **Mirror it back.** Name what you see, plainly. No praise, no fixing, no interrogation.
- 2 **Reach for the environment, not the child.** A card is a request to change the conditions. Change them.
- 3 **Leave the sharing with the child.** What they turn up is theirs to turn up.

If it's not working, it's not the child.

Not a screening tool. A spread is the child telling you something — not you assessing them. No pathology paradigm, no deficit ideology, no behaviorism: a card names a need, never a symptom or a target.

Broken systems, not broken people. The deck exists so a child can shape the space around them — and so the people beside them can read what they need without asking a child to explain in words they may not have.

Free to use, print, and adapt. **CC0 1.0.**

Home: stimpunks.org/projects/cavendish-space-project

The screen-reader-friendly source is the Markdown version of this sheet in the repository.

